



WRITING A RESEARCH REPORT

If research was not “written up,” did it really occur?

Book Reference: Sekaran, Uma, and Roger Bougie. Research methods for business: A skill building approach. John Wiley & Sons, 2016.



What is a Research Report?

Research report is a document written in a structured format, following specific guidelines or standards, and is used to communicate the outcomes of research to relevant stakeholders, such as funding agencies, or decision-makers.

Characteristics of Report

- The key **purpose** of any research report is to offer a clear description of what has been done in the various stages of the research process.
- Who is your **audience**: The organization of a report, its length, focus on details, data presentation, and illustrations will, in part, be a function of the audience for whom it is intended.
 - *Executive Summary*
 - *Choice of words*
 - *Facts and Figures*
 - *Unpleasant Findings: non-judgmental, non-fault-finding or finger-pointing manner, using objective data and facts*
- The report should be **organized** in a manner that enhances the meaningful and smooth flow of materials.

Writing a Research Report

- A sociological article, paper, or report generally covers only one topic of interest that is judged important enough to spend resources on.
 - *It is focused*
 - *It is concise*
 - *It states information matter-of-factly*
 - *It has its own voice—it is not a cut and paste accumulation of facts*

Components/Parts/ Sections of Research

A research report has the following components:

1. *The title and the title page*
2. *Abstract or Executive Summary*
3. *Introduction*
4. *Review of Literature*
5. *Methods*
6. *Results*
7. *Conclusions and Discussion*
8. *References*
9. *Appendix (Tables, Figures, Questionnaire)*

Writing a Research Report

1. The Title or a Title Page

A first idea of your study and to decide whether they want to read your report in its entirety.

- Catchy to grab attention (quotes, proverbs, or popular movie and song titles)
- Subtitles can be added

– Examples:

- "The Impact of Fiscal Policy on Economic Growth: A Comparative Analysis"
- "Income Inequality and its Effect on Economic Development: A Longitudinal Study"
- "Money Talks: Unraveling the Mysteries of Behavioral Economics"
- "Green Gold: The Economic Impacts of Sustainable Agriculture"

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2. Abstract or Executive Summary

The abstract or summary tells the reader very briefly what the main points and findings of the paper are.

- An executive summary (in the case of applied research)
- An abstract (in the case of basic research)
- *This allows the reader to decide whether the paper is useful to them.*
- *Get into the habit of reading only abstracts while searching for papers that are relevant to your research.*
- *Read the body of a paper only when you think it will be useful to you.*

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2. Abstract or Executive Summary: Example

Exports and Economic Growth in Pakistan: An Empirical Analysis

Muhammad Azam*

Abstract

A close positive relationship between expansion in exports of a country and economic development has been observed by a good number of researchers theoretically as well empirically. The aim of this research is to investigate empirically the impacts of exports and foreign direct investment (hereafter FDI) on economic growth in Pakistan. Empirical results show positive significant impacts of exports and FDI on economic growth. Thus, findings of this study suggest that policy makers need to generate appropriate policy in order to increase the volume of exports and augment FDI inflows.

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The logo of the University of Poonch is centered in the background. It features a shield-like emblem with a yellow banner across the middle containing the university's name in Urdu. The emblem is flanked by stylized blue and white architectural elements.

3. Introduction

The introduction tells the reader what the topic of the paper is in general terms, why the topic is important, and what to expect in the paper.

- Introductions should narrow down general ideas to the specific topic of the paper*
- What are the research objectives, research questions and significance of research*

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3. Introduction: Example

Introduction

The significance of the exports for economic expansion is evident from the writings of classical as well as many modern economists. According to Marshall (1890), a nation's economic progress belongs to the study of international trade. Nurkse (1961) called international trade as an engine of growth. For efficient utilization of available scarce resources and for expanding global trade volume, free trade in goods and services is commendable Bhagwati (1973). It has been observed that there is a close positive relationship between expansion in exports of a country and economic development. High and rapidly growing economies are usually characterized by speedy expansion in exports. However, it is critical to note that expansion in exports is possible not just in countries endowed with plentiful natural resources. Even less developed countries with scarce natural resources can introduce appropriate economic policies to transform scarce resources from inefficient domestic use to dynamic export production. Moreover, it is also important that exports are not be limited to primary products only but should to be extended to final exportable products which are high in value added with high backward linkages in order to create dynamism in the economy.

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4. Review of Literature

The literature review tells the reader what other researchers have discovered about the paper's topic or tells the reader about other research that is relevant to the topic.

- *A literature review should shape the way readers think about a topic—it educates readers about what the community of scholars says about a topic and its surrounding issues.*
- *Literature reviews have citations running throughout. These are part of a systematic way to document where facts and ideas came from, allowing the skeptical reader to look up anything that is questionable.*
- *Literature reviews typically end with statements of:*
 - *Research hypotheses:*
 - *“Men have higher investment income than women”*

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5. *Methods*

- Names for the variables
- Target Population
- The Ways Data were Collected:
 - *Sampling*
 - *Delivery Methods*
- Response Rates
- Sample sizes

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6. Results

- *The statistical tests one used to describe the sample statistics and to make inferences to the population.*
- *The author writes explanations of the most important findings for the reader.*
- *Evaluations of the hypotheses. Were the research hypotheses supported?*
- *Statements about new discoveries or surprises encountered in the analyses*

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7. Conclusions and Discussion

This section assesses how one's research findings relate to what the community of scholars knew already.

- You should summarize the most salient points of your research (tell the reader what you found out about your topic).*
- Discuss the general significance of your topic and findings.*
- Limitations of Research*
- Implications/Benefits of Research*

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8. References

The references are just as important as any other part of your paper. They are the link to the community of scholars that will permit your reader to assess the worthiness of the claims you make in your paper. References also make the research process much more efficient because they make it very easy to look up sources of facts and ideas.

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8. References—example

References

Abou-Stait, F. 2005. *Are Exports the Engine of Economic Growth? An Application of Cointegration and Causality Analysis for Egypt, 1977-2003*. African Development Bank Economic Research Working Paper .No 76

Ahmed, Q. S. Butt, and Alam S. 2000. Economic Growth, Export, and External Debt Causality: The Case of Asian Countries. *The Pakistan Development Review*, 39(4), 591-608.

Alireza K., E., and Samane G. 2005. *Impact of Foreign Direct Investment and Trade on Economic Growth*. Economic Research Forum, 12th Annual Conference, 19th–21th December 2005, Grand Hyatt, Cairo, Egypt.

Aurangzeb 2006. Exports, Productivity and Economic Growth in Pakistan: A Time Series Analysis. *The Lahore Journal of Economics*. 11: (1), 01-18

Content of Report

- ✓ Title of your study
- ✓ Table of Content
- ✓ Executive Summary/Abstract of study
- ✓ Introduction of Study
 - ✓ *Background of Study*
 - ✓ *Research Problem*
 - ✓ *Research Questions*
 - ✓ *Scope of the study*
 - ✓ *Flow of Study*
- ✓ Literature Review
 - ✓ *Hypotheses Development*
 - ✓ *Theoretical Framework (Schematic Diagram)*
- ✓ Research Methodology
 - ✓ *Sampling Technique*
 - ✓ *Data Collection Techniques*
 - ✓ *Data Analysis Techniques*
- ✓ Results and Findings
- ✓ Discussion on Findings
 - ✓ *Conclusion*
 - ✓ *Limitations of Study*
 - ✓ *Implications of Study (for the selected sector and future researchers)*
- ✓ References and Appendices



Class Activity



Develop a research proposal in the field of economics through the content of report shared in the previous slides?